Because lately he'd refashioned himself into some sort of quasi royal correspondent, largely on the strength of his secret relationship with one particularly close friend of Willy's comms secretary—who fed him trivial (and mostly fake) gossip.

He was sure to get everything wrong, as he'd got everything wrong on his last big "exclusive," Tiaragate. He was equally sure to cram his story into the paper as fast as possible, because he was likely working in concert with the Palace, whose courtiers were determined to get ahead of us and spin the story. We didn't want that. We didn't want anyone else breaking our news, *twisting* our news.

We'd have to rush out a statement.

I phoned Granny again, told her about *The Sun*, told her we might need to hurry out a statement. She understood. She'd allow it, so long as it didn't "add to speculation."

I didn't tell her exactly what our statement would say. She didn't ask. But also I didn't fully know yet. I gave her the gist, however, and mentioned some of the basic details I'd outlined in the memo Pa had demanded and which she'd seen.

The wording needed to be precise. And it needed to be bland—calm. We didn't want to assign any blame, didn't want to stoke the fires. Mustn't add to speculation.

Formidable writing challenge.

We soon realized it wasn't possible; we didn't have time to get our statement out there first.

We opened a bottle of wine. Proceed, sad little man, proceed.

He did. *The Sun* posted his story late that night, and again on the morning's front page.

Headline: WE'RE ORF!

As expected, the story depicted our departure as a rollicking, carefree, hedonistic *tapping out*, rather than a careful retreat and attempt at self-preservation. It also included the telling detail that we'd offered to relinquish our Sussex titles. There was only one document on earth in which that detail was mentioned—my private and confidential letter to my father.